

French châteaux

Renaissance architectural interpretations in France emerged chiefly in the grand châteaux, built for royalty and the nobility. L'Orme and Bullant designed and rebuilt the Château de Chenonceau (opposite, 1514–22) in the Loire Valley with elaborate windows, chimneys and turrets, and an elegant five-arched bridge that reflects in the River Cher beneath. Inspired by a sketch by Leonardo da Vinci, the Tuscan architect Domenico da Cortona (c.1465–c.1549) designed and built the Château de Chambord (1519–47) for Francis I. Although it has many Gothic features, Chambord also expresses the Italian Renaissance in its symmetry and elaborate ornamentation. Built on a rectangular plan, it has enormous round towers at each corner, dormer windows, turrets, plus a main hall built to a Greek cross plan and an unusual double-helix openwork staircase. Architects Gilles le Breton (d.1553) and Sebastiano Serlio rebuilt the medieval Château de Fontainebleau (1528–47) for Francis I; the oval courtyard, private king's gallery, huge oval stairway and garden are key Renaissance additions.

